

An Integrated Model of Cognition, Emotion, and Vote Choice: Evidence from Taiwan

Abstract

Political behavior research has long emphasized either cognitive evaluations or candidate-centered affect in explaining vote choice, leaving less attention to emotions elicited by the broader political environment. Drawing on appraisal theory and affective intelligence theory, this study develops and tests a framework in which retrospective evaluations and environment-elicited emotions operate as parallel pathways that may interact under particular appraisal conditions to shape electoral choice. Using post-election survey data from Taiwan's 2024 presidential election, I examine how evaluations of Taiwan's international status and cross-Strait relations, together with anxiety about military conflict and anger toward Chinese coercion, influence support for the incumbent. The results show that voters who perceive Taiwan's international standing as deteriorating are substantially less likely to support the incumbent. Anxiety is negatively associated with incumbent support, but this relationship reverses among voters who perceive severe national decline, suggesting that anxiety promotes continuity when political change is viewed as especially risky; this reversal, like the anger finding below, is evident under baseline controls but does not survive the inclusion of comparative candidate-evaluation controls. These findings reveal important differences in the political consequences of anxiety and anger, while demonstrating that retrospective evaluations and discrete emotions jointly shape electoral accountability. They also suggest that the electoral effects of environment-elicited emotions depend on both citizens' appraisal of political conditions and the relationship between those emotions and candidate evaluations.

Introduction

Research on voting behavior has long emphasized that citizens rely on cognitive considerations—such as issue preferences, retrospective performance evaluations, and candidate assessments—when making electoral choices (Fiorina 1981; Lau and Sears 1981; Jackson 1975; Kinder and Kiewit 1979; Lodge, Steenbergen, and Brau 1995). A complementary tradition demonstrates that affective predispositions, especially partisanship, guide information processing and shape evaluative orientations (Campbell et al. 1960; Jacoby 1988; Greene 1999; Bartels 2000). This body of work establishes that cognition and affect both matter, but it focuses

primarily on attitudes and emotions directed at candidates or parties, rather than the reactions citizens form in response to the political environment they face.

By contrast, psychological theories suggest that individuals continually interpret their environment through both evaluative and emotional lenses. Appraisal theory and affective intelligence emphasize that political conditions—uncertainty, risk, coercion, crisis—simultaneously elicit cognitive judgments and emotional reactions, each with distinct behavioral implications (Roseman, 1984; Lerner and Keltner, 2000; Marcus, Neuman, and MacKuen, 2000; Ellsworth and Scherer, 2003; Huddy, Feldman, and Cassese 2007). Yet the political behavior literature seldom incorporates these environment-elicited emotions into models of vote choice. Existing work tends to examine emotions triggered by campaign stimuli or candidate impressions (Abelson et al. 1982; Glaser and Salovey 1998; Isbell and Ottati, 2002). Some research finds how broader political conditions generate emotions and influence attitudes and behavior (Wagner and Morisi 2019; Rico, Guinjoan, and Anduiza 2017; Vasilopoulos et al. 2019), but this work leaves unexplored how these reactions combine with cognitive evaluations to shape electoral decisions. A comprehensive model of vote choice must retain both cognition and emotion because many contemporary appraisal theories treat cognitive evaluation and emotional response as simultaneous outputs of the same appraisal process rather than one causing the other, so they can move independently and interactively. While cognitive performance evaluations guide vote choice through reasoned assessment, discrete emotions like anxiety and anger act concurrently, triggering unique motivational drives (Erisen 2020).

Drawing insights from appraisal theory and affective intelligence theory, this study offers an empirical examination of cognitive and emotional pathways to vote choice under sustained external coercion, using a non-US case, and suggests evidence consistent with a context-dependent reversal in anxiety's effect that existing dual-process accounts do not foresee. By “integrated,” I refer to a framework in which cognitive evaluations and discrete emotions operate as distinct and co-occurring pathways rather than competing or sequential explanations. These two mechanisms --broad political evaluation and discrete emotional response—operate independently but may intersect when emotions condition how strongly individuals weight negative evaluations. By theorizing cognition and emotion as simultaneous but context-

dependent pathways, this paper offers a nuanced psychological correction to existing voting models.

The 2024 Taiwan presidential election presents an ideal case for examining these processes. Taiwan faces continuous military and diplomatic coercion from China, making evaluations of international status and cross-Strait relations highly salient. These same conditions trigger anxiety about military conflict between Taiwan and mainland China, and anger over military incursions. The coexistence of chronic external pressure and competitive multiparty politics allows us to directly test how voters combine cognitive assessments of national conditions with emotional reactions to the surrounding environment.

Using nationally representative survey data from Taiwan's 2024 presidential election, this study makes three contributions to research on political behavior. First, it extends retrospective voting models by incorporating environment-elicited emotions alongside cognitive evaluations, distinguishing emotions arising from the broader political environment—such as external coercion and perceived national decline—from the candidate-centered affect that has dominated previous research. Second, under increasingly conservative controls for candidate evaluations, anxiety exerts a stable association with incumbent support across every specification, whereas anger's association weakens and becomes statistically indistinguishable from zero once comparative candidate-feeling measures are included. This asymmetry suggests that anxiety is more readily distinguishable from candidate-centered affect, whereas anger's electoral association partly overlaps with comparative leadership evaluations. Third, this research refines appraisal-based accounts of political behavior by suggesting that anxiety's electoral consequences are context-dependent: anxiety may promote punishment when conditions appear manageable but favor continuity when political change is perceived as especially risky. Like anger's incumbent-benefiting association, this reversal is evident under baseline and partial controls but weakens once comprehensive candidate-affect controls are introduced, so it is best read as suggestive rather than conclusive. No comparable pattern emerges for anger's *directional* association, which remains stable across levels of perceived decline even as its overall magnitude attenuates.

Based on the mechanisms identified here, the findings reframe emotion as a meaningful part of rational political decision-making. Anxiety's effect on incumbent support should depend on how bad the situation seems — supportive of punishment when conditions still look manageable, but potentially protective of familiar leadership once conditions look severe. Anger's effect, by contrast, should stay comparatively stable regardless of how severe the situation looks, so long as voters can pin blame on someone. This distinction points to a simple rule: when a crisis has a clear, blameworthy culprit — a corrupt official, a scandal-plagued agency — anger-like dynamics should dominate. When a crisis is diffuse and no single actor is clearly at fault — a recession, a pandemic — anxiety-like dynamics should dominate instead.

The next sections develop the theoretical framework, derive empirical predictions, and evaluate them using original survey data.

Cognition and Emotion as Parallel Pathways

Citizens judge their government largely through assessments of performance--domestic and foreign policy--such as international reputation or security performance (Aldrich, Sullivan, and Borgida 1989; Gelpi, Reifler, and Feaver 2007; Druckman and Lupia 2000). Yet purely cognitive accounts often understate the influence of emotion on political judgment (Lodge and Taber 2013). A large literature shows that emotions generated by political actors shape evaluation and choice: affective reactions to candidates guide candidate evaluation (Abelson et al. 1982; Isbell and Ottati 2002), emotional responses predict vote preference (Marcus 1988), and affect expressed by candidates increases attention, memory, and favorability (Glaser and Salovey 1998).

However, these studies focus primarily on affect directed toward candidates or parties, leaving comparatively little attention to emotional responses elicited by the broader political environment, such as uncertainty, risk, or external coercion, and how those emotions shape the electoral consequences of cognitive evaluations. Psychological research increasingly views cognition and emotion as complementary rather than competing processes. Rather than treating emotion as a by-product of deliberative reasoning, contemporary theories argue that individuals simultaneously interpret political events through evaluative judgments and affective appraisals, both of which contribute to decision making (Zajonc 1984; Ellsworth and Scherer 2003; Moors et al. 2013).

Structural appraisal theory holds that specific appraisal dimensions—certainty, controllability, other-blame—generate a cognitive evaluation and a discrete emotion, though appraisal theorists disagree about timing: some treat cognition as typically preceding affect (Huddy, Feldman, and Cassese 2007; Lazarus 1991), while others treat the appraisal itself as occurring outside conscious awareness, generating evaluation and emotion together rather than in sequence (Roseman, Abelson, and Ewing 1986; Smith and Ellsworth 1985). Affective intelligence theory (AIT) resolves this ambiguity for political behavior specifically, proposing that appraisals of uncertainty and threat route through functionally distinct systems—a surveillance system governing anxiety and a disposition system governing anger and confidence—allowing these emotions to move independently of, and in tandem with, cognitive evaluations of the same political conditions (Marcus, Neuman, and MacKuen 2000; MacKuen et al. 2007; MacKuen et al. 2010).

A terminological clarification is warranted here. Following convention in political behavior research, this paper uses 'cognition' and 'cognitive evaluation' to refer to consciously accessible, deliberative judgments—such as retrospective performance assessments—as distinct from discrete emotional reactions. This is narrower than AIT's own theoretical claim, in which preconscious affective appraisals are themselves functionally cognitive, occurring below conscious awareness rather than outside cognition altogether (Marcus, Neuman, and MacKuen 2000; Marcus 2002). The dual-pathway framework advanced here is best understood as distinguishing *conscious, deliberative evaluation* from *discrete emotional response*, not as opposing cognition to emotion in AIT's stricter theoretical sense.

Taken together, I argue that voter behavior reflects a dual-pathway process in which cognitive evaluations and emotional appraisals inform electoral choice. In line with Crawford's (2000:156) characterization that "humans make decisions that are always both classically self-interested and emotional," this study does not treat cognition as the cause of emotion. Instead, cognition and emotion arise simultaneously as inputs of how individuals make voting decisions, each carrying distinct implications for political judgment. Existing voting models explain why citizens punish governments when they perceive poor performance, but they are less informative about why citizens making similar evaluations sometimes reach different electoral decisions. The argument developed here is that emotional reactions constitute an additional source of variation.

Anxiety and Anger

AIT identifies distinct emotional systems that regulate attention and behavioral motivation. Anxiety arises when individuals determine a stimulus or event as uncertain, potentially harmful, and beyond personal control. This emotion heightens vigilance, directs attention toward potential losses, increases information seeking, and encourages cautious or change-oriented behavior (Marcus and MacKuen 1993; Lerner and Keltner 2000; Wagner and Morisi 2019). It motivates behavior aimed at moving away from danger, hiding, or searching the environment for safety (Frijda 1986; Huddy, Feldman, and Cassese 2007). For example, anxious Americans were significantly less supportive than their non-anxious counterparts of assertive antiterrorism policies, including military intervention, in the aftermath of September 11 (Huddy et al. 2005).

Anger, by contrast, is elicited by a threat with certainty (Gadarian and Brader 2023:203). It emerges when individuals perceive a threat as certain, intentional, and blameworthy, heightening blame, punitive preferences, and mobilization (Banks and Valentino 2012; Valentino et al. 2011; Banks 2014). Other-blame and control differentiate anger from other negative emotions (Lazarus 1991; Smith and Lazarus 1993). Therefore, anger activates approach motivation, punishment of the responsible actor, and support for assertive or confrontational responses based on optimistic risk assessments (Huddy, Feldman, Weber 2007; Lerner and Keltner 2001). Within AIT specifically, anger operates through the disposition system, prompting citizens to rely more heavily on prior attitudes, resist attitude-challenging information, and become more resolute rather than more persuadable (MacKuen et al. 2010).

Work directly contrasting anger and anxiety in political contexts reinforces this divergence. Anxiety motivates people to pay closer attention to relevant information, supporting protective policies for reassurance (Albertson and Gadarian 2015). Anger, however, produces stronger resistance to counter-attitudinal information than anxiety does, as angry individuals engage in more biased assimilation of arguments that challenge their prior views (Suhay and Erisen 2018). At the same time, anger's mobilizing function may not be strictly contingent on the threat's external locus: Webster (2018, 2020) shows that anger operates as a generalized mobilizer of political engagement, and that even as it erodes diffuse institutional trust, it simultaneously strengthens partisan loyalty in voting behavior. This raises the possibility that anger's electoral

consequences in the present case may be relatively stable across levels of perceived threat, rather than conditional on how citizens evaluate the trajectory of the threat itself. This pattern is consistent with the broader distinction motivating the hypotheses: anger's electoral influence is rooted in stable dispositional attachments, while anxiety's influence is more closely tied to real-time appraisal of threat and uncertainty.

As established above, AIT's account of concurrent affective appraisal means voters can hold a cognitive judgment about national conditions while simultaneously experiencing both anxiety (from the uncertainty of potential conflict) and anger (from the perceived intentionality of Chinese military coercion), rather than one emotion crowding out the other. Because anger's blame appraisal identifies a responsible agent, its electoral expression should be more entangled with evaluations of which candidate is a credible respondent to that agent, whereas anxiety's diffuse, target-general character (Huddy, Feldman, and Cassese 2007) should make it comparatively insulated from candidate-specific affect. The distinctiveness of these two emotional pathways is therefore not only expected to manifest in the sign of their baseline associations with incumbent support, but in their differential sensitivity to candidate-affect controls. Accordingly, I expect anxiety to reduce support for the incumbent in Taiwan's 2024 election, while anger—directed here at an external antagonist more than government performance itself—is expected to benefit the incumbent by shifting responsibility outward. Anger's incumbent-benefiting association is expected to be substantially attenuated once citizens' evaluations of the candidates are taken into account, consistent with its entanglement with existing candidate and party attachments; anxiety's association, operating more independently of those attachments, is expected to persist.

A final caveat concerns the measurement of emotion. Anxiety and anger are conceptually linked because both arise from the same external threat, but they refer to different aspects of that threat—potential conflict versus experienced coercion. Consequently, some of the observed differences may reflect differences in object as well as emotion type. I return to this limitation in the Discussion.

The preceding framework yields clear expectations about how cognition and emotion shape electoral behavior. I formalize these expectations as hypotheses after presenting the background of the 2024 Taiwan's presidential election.

Context: Taiwan's 2024 Presidential Election

The 2024 Taiwan presidential election unfolded amid intensified Chinese military coercion, making cross-Strait relations a central issue. The incumbent Democratic Progressive Party (DPP) nominated Lai Ching-te, then serving as vice president under outgoing president Tsai Ing-wen, who emphasized deterrence and sovereignty—continuing the DPP's existing defense posture and refusal to negotiate under coercion, and appealing to voters who opposed accommodating Chinese pressure (Yang 2023). The opposition Kuomintang (KMT) nominated Hou Yu-ih, who advocated resuming cross-Strait dialogue and criticized the DPP's approach as needlessly escalatory and risky (Bush 2023). Ko Wen-je of the Taiwan People's Party (TPP) offered a third path, criticizing both Beijing's coercion and the DPP's handling of it, which complicates any simple deterrence-versus-dialogue dichotomy for voters who supported him. The election was closely contested: Lai ultimately won with 40.1 percent of the vote in a three-way race, short of a majority, against a backdrop in which cross-Strait policy was arguably one of the key issues (Yu 2023). This context establishes the incumbent's policy stance—assertive deterrence rather than accommodation—that motivates the scope condition hypothesis, developed in the next section, and the three-candidate structure that motivates the dependent-variable discussion below.¹

Independent Effects on Incumbent Support

Drawing from retrospective voting logic, negative evaluations of national standing should reduce support for the incumbent. When voters perceive worsening international status or heightened cross-Strait tension, they may attribute responsibility to the government and punish it electorally. This establishes the first expectation:

H1 (Cognitive Punishment Hypothesis):

Voters who perceive Taiwan's international or cross-Strait situation as deteriorating will be less likely to support the incumbent party.

Emotion introduces a second pathway. Anxiety, by signaling uncertainty and the potential for harm, encourages citizens to reconsider the status quo and to become risk averse. Anger, in contrast, is associated with blame and mobilization against the perceived threat, which in contexts of external coercion can strengthen defensive solidarity with incumbents. This mechanism parallels arguments in the rally-'round-the-flag literature, but departs from that literature's assumption of a uniform emotional reaction to threat. By distinguishing anxiety from anger, the theory predicts opposing electoral forces.

H2 (Anxiety-induced Weakening Support Hypothesis):

Higher levels of anxiety about potential military conflict will decrease support for the incumbent party.

The direction of anger's effect, however, should depend on the incumbent's own policy stance toward the external threat: anger should benefit incumbents who respond with assertive deterrence, channeling blame outward and rewarding a confrontational posture, but may not benefit—or could even penalize—incumbents who favor accommodation or dialogue, since angry voters would see conciliatory leadership as an inadequate response to a threat that is certain and blameworthy. The hypothesis below is scoped to the former case, consistent with the DPP's deterrence-oriented platform in the 2024 election.

H3 (Anger-induced Strengthening Support Hypothesis):

Higher levels of anger at external coercion are expected to increase support for an incumbent pursuing a deterrence-oriented stance.

A caveat is necessary here. The incumbent's deterrence-oriented stance is a scope condition rather than a tested moderator: because the analysis examines a single election in which the incumbent DPP pursued a deterrence-oriented policy toward China, the present design

cannot establish whether anger would have different electoral consequences under an accommodation-oriented incumbent.

Because anger's electoral force is expected to operate substantially by reinforcing voters' existing candidate and party attachments rather than as a fully independent reaction to the threat, this association should attenuate once those standing attachments — measured here via candidate feeling-thermometer differences — are directly controlled for.

Interaction Between Cognitive Evaluation and Anxiety

Prior studies suggest that anxiety increases vigilance, heightens attention to potential losses, and encourages risk-averse, change-avoidant behavior (Marcus and MacKuen 1993; Lerner and Keltner 2000). This risk aversion has divergent implications depending on the baseline political context. Under stable or improving conditions, punishing an underperforming incumbent is a low-stakes choice; risk aversion does little to discourage it. Under conditions that voters already perceive as deteriorating, however, switching to an untested opposition becomes the riskier option—it entails trading a known quantity for uncertainty during a period already defined by uncertainty. Anxious voters, driven by the same aversion to risk and change that ordinarily predicts vigilance and punishment, may therefore prefer the perceived safety of established leadership precisely when conditions are worst. When a voter feels angry over a political object or event, that emotional reaction interrupts the usual cognitive mechanism that blames the government. Even if the voter perceives the international situation as worsening, anger cues them to attribute the cause externally, weakening the electoral relevance of the cognitive judgment.

In the Taiwanese context, this means that anxiety about conflict should attenuate or reverse the electoral penalty for perceived diplomatic deterioration under conditions of severe perceived decline, as anxious voters gravitate toward the status quo rather than the added uncertainty of political change. Anger, by contrast, shifts blame to the adversary. Therefore, I propose the following hypothesis:

H4 (Anxiety-Contingent Reversal Hypothesis):

Under perceptions of worsening national standing, anxiety will attenuate or reverse the negative effect of that evaluation on incumbent support, as anxious voters favor the perceived security of familiar leadership over the uncertainty of political change.

Taken together, my theory combines two distinct mechanisms—cognitive evaluations and discrete emotions—and a key interaction: negative evaluations reduce incumbent support. Under conditions of severe perceived decline, anxiety attenuates or reverses this effect as voters gravitate toward tested leadership. Instead, anger moves voters in the opposite direction of cognitive punishment by shifting blame externally. These propositions guide the empirical analysis that follows. Table 1 summarizes the four hypotheses to be tested.

Table 1. Cognition, Emotion, and Support for Incumbents

Hypothesis	Prediction
H1(Cognitive Punishment)	Perceived deterioration in international status or cross-Strait relations is associated with lower incumbent support
H2(Anxiety-induced Weakening)	Higher anxiety about potential conflict induces lower incumbent support
H3(Anger-induced Strengthening)	For an incumbent pursuing a deterrence-oriented stance, higher level of anger at external coercion induces higher incumbent support
H4(Anxiety-Contingent Reversal)	Under perceived decline, anxiety attenuates or reverses the negative effect of that evaluation on incumbent support

Source: Author

Stated generally, this framework predicts that (1) negative evaluations of government-relevant conditions reduce incumbent support; (2) anxiety about a diffuse, attributionally ambiguous threat further weakens this effect, or reverses it under conditions of severe perceived decline, as risk-averse voters shift from punishing the incumbent to protecting familiar leadership; and (3) anger at a threat with an identifiable, blameworthy source strengthens support for incumbents who respond to that threat assertively. In the Taiwan case, these general

propositions map onto perceptions of international status and cross-Straits relations (H1), anxiety about potential conflict (H2 and H4), and anger at Chinese coercion (H3), respectively.

Data and Variables

My analysis leverages data from the Taiwan Election and Democratization Study (TEDS) (Chen 2024). The 2024 TEDS survey was conducted by the Election Study Center at National Chengchi University between January 15 and May 31, 2024. The data are drawn from a nationally representative probability sample of Taiwanese adults. The research team systematically selected 14,503 residential addresses, from which 1,206 face-to-face interviews were successfully completed. This study was approved by Institutional Review Board of National Chengchi University (approve no. NCCU-REC-202007-I073 v.24) on December 23, 2023. The data are deposited at Survey Research Data Archive, Academia Sinica (<https://doi.org/10.6141/TW-SRDA-D00260-1>).

Independent Variables

To test the cognition–emotion framework, I distinguish between citizens’ evaluative judgments of national conditions and their emotional reactions to the same external environment. Consistent with retrospective and foreign-policy voting research, cognitive appraisal is measured using two items that capture respondents’ assessments of Taiwan’s international position: (1) whether Taiwan’s *international status* has improved, remained the same, or deteriorated over the past four years; and (2) whether *cross-Straits relations* have improved, remained stable, or worsened. These items directly reflect voters’ judgments about the government’s diplomatic management and perceived national standing. Emotional appraisal is measured using two discrete emotions central to appraisal theory and affective intelligence—anxiety and anger. Anxiety is captured by respondents’ worry about potential military conflict, reflecting an uncertainty-based hazard appraisal. Anger is measured by respondents’ feeling of being upset over China’s encirclement of Taiwan with military aircraft and vessels, reflecting a blame-based appraisal of intentional coercion.

These measures capture the outcome-level predictions AIT and structural appraisal theory generate—that anxiety and anger, once elicited, differentially shape political evaluation—rather than the process-level mechanisms these theories describe. In particular, AIT's account centrally concerns how anxiety alters information search and reliance on partisan cues during deliberation; the present design, using a single post-election survey, does not observe this process directly. Nor do I measure the finer-grained appraisal dimensions (e.g., controllability, responsibility) that structural appraisal theories treat as generating discrete emotions. The anxiety and anger measures are treated as theory-inspired proxies for these underlying appraisal and information-processing constructs, and the results as consistent with, rather than a direct test of, the full theoretical mechanisms proposed by AIT and appraisal theory.

People's responses to foreign threats may reflect the domestic political environment (Myrick 2021). To account for partisan alignment without conditioning on a potentially endogenous variable, the models instead include respondents' vote choice in the 2020 presidential election. This lagged measure—coded as DPP vs. KMT and People's First Party (PFP)—captures preexisting partisan predispositions while exogenous to the emotional and evaluative processes triggered by recent developments. Analyses using current partisanship as a robustness check yield similar patterns in Table C1 in Appendix C, but the main specification relies on lagged vote to better isolate the influence of emotion and cognition on 2024 vote intention. The weighted distribution of 2020 presidential votes in the sample (DPP 64.4%, KMT/PFP 35.6%) slightly overstates support for the incumbent relative to official results (57.1% vs. 42.9%). This deviation, while consistent with common patterns of incumbent-party overreporting in post-election surveys, is a caveat on the generalizability of point estimates to the full electorate. The theoretical mechanisms under study are not expected to depend on this compositional skew, but readers should treat descriptive comparisons across candidate coalitions with appropriate caution. I run a subgroup analysis for people who voted for the DPP in 2020 and present the results in Table C2.²

Since citizens' feelings toward political leaders strongly predict attitude and behavior (Iyengar et al., 2019), it is necessary to rule out affective bias. I employ the difference in feeling thermometer scores, rather than affect toward Lai alone, because differences isolate relative candidate affect net of a respondent's general mood or tendency to rate all candidates uniformly warmly or coolly. In other words, the feeling difference variable can provide a cleaner control for

candidate-based affect that is conceptually distinct from the discrete, environment-elicited emotions of central interest in this study.

In addition, Taiwanese identity has been the most salient cleavage (Achen and Wang 2017). Thus, I include Taiwanese identity in the voting model. See Appendix B for the full question wording.

Dependent Variable: Voting Choice

Because the 2024 election featured three major candidates, the operationalization of the dependent variable carries theoretical weight. To test hypotheses about *incumbent* support specifically: whether cognitive evaluations and discrete emotions lead voters to punish or reward the sitting government, I code the outcome as a binary indicator of incumbent support—DPP versus either opposition candidate—rather than modeling the full three-way choice as the primary specification. Collapsing the two opposition candidates into a single category directly matches the theoretical quantity of interest.

The dependent variable, support for the incumbent, is operationalized as a vote for the DPP ticket (Lai Ching-te/Hsiao Bi-khim), who successfully retained the presidency. Respondents that said they did not turn out to vote or refused to answer this question are dropped from the analysis. Because the dependent variable is dichotomous, I estimate binary logit regression models to estimate the effect of each independent variable. To ensure that my findings do not vary with the setting of the dependent variable, I also separate KMT and TPP and run a multinomial logit model with TPP as the baseline category. The results are presented in Table C4, C5, and C6 in Appendix.

This survey is post-stratified to be nationally representative. Since my goal is theoretical explanation of emotional and cognitive mechanisms in voting under external coercion but not population estimation, all regression analyses use unweighted data. Weighted descriptive statistics are reported to ensure sample representativeness. Robustness checks using survey weights yield substantively identical results in Table C7.

Results

Table 2 reports odds ratios from logistic regressions predicting the likelihood of voting for the incumbent. The baseline model includes voters' electoral decisions in 2020, retrospective evaluations of Taiwan's international status and cross-Strait relations, emotional responses (anxiety and anger), interaction terms between cognitive evaluations and emotional reactions, and sociodemographic controls.³ To assess whether the estimated emotional effects merely reflect candidate-centered affect, I progressively introduce comparative feeling thermometer measures. Models 2 and 3 separately control for affect toward Lai relative to Hou and Lai relative to Ko, and Model 4 includes both measures simultaneously. Because comparative candidate evaluations may themselves be influenced by emotional reactions to the external political environment, specifications controlling for them should be interpreted as conservative estimates of the independent association between environment-elicited emotions and vote choice.

The baseline model shows that voters who perceive Taiwan's international status became worse are significantly less likely to support the DPP ($OR \approx 0.013$), even after accounting for previous voting behavior and emotional reactions, implying that voters punish incumbents for perceived diplomatic decline. Voters who perceive Taiwan's international status as *deteriorating* are only about 1.3% as likely to support the incumbent DPP compared to those who perceive the status as *improving* (the reference category). Evaluations of cross-Strait relations are weaker predictors. This may reflect that cross-Strait rhetoric was more moderated by all three candidates than international-status framing during the 2024 campaign, which may have compressed variation in how sharply voters distinguished candidates on this dimension.

H2 suggests that anxiety tends to correlate with withdrawing from the status quo (Plutchik 1984:200). In the baseline model, level of anxiety about potential military conflict is negatively associated with voting for the DPP ($OR \approx 0.308$); while this item is specifically anchored to cross-Strait military conflict, I discuss in the Conclusion the possibility that broader domestic uncertainty in 2024 may also have contributed to this anxiety. This negative association represents anxiety's effect under the reference category of stable or improving international status; as discussed below, this relationship becomes conditional once voters perceive national decline.

In the baseline model, anger over China's coercion is positively associated with incumbent support ($OR \approx 2.509$). This pattern is consistent with defensive solidarity against an external adversary, and more broadly with the classic rally-'round-the-flag hypothesis (Mueller 1970). Models 2 and 3 separately introduce comparative feeling-thermometer differences between Lai and Hou and between Lai and Ko. The principal findings remain largely unchanged. Retrospective evaluations of Taiwan's international standing and anxiety continue to predict incumbent support, whereas the positive association between anger weakens once comparative candidate evaluations are taken into account, particularly when the Lai–Ko feeling difference is included. This pattern is consistent with the interpretation that anger overlaps more closely with candidate-centered affect than anxiety. Predicted probabilities for these alternative specifications are presented in Appendix D. Relative to the baseline model, the difference between evaluations of Taiwan's international standing becomes somewhat smaller, but the substantive pattern remains similar.

The progressive specifications in Model 4 reveal an important asymmetry between anxiety and anger. Anxiety remains a stable predictor of incumbent support across all four models, whereas the association between anger and incumbent support weakens as increasingly comprehensive controls for candidate affect are introduced. Relatedly, Table C8 shows that anger and the anxiety $\times$ worsening-international-status interaction central to H4 reach significance only under party-level controls alone. This attenuation suggests that anger partly overlaps with candidate-centered affect, whereas anxiety captures a more distinct emotional response to the external security environment. Deterrence-oriented incumbency may operate partly through candidate evaluations rather than exclusively through an independent emotional pathway. In the context of Taiwan's 2024 election, this asymmetry suggests that anger's apparent incumbent-benefiting effect is disproportionately bound up with how voters evaluate Ko specifically, consistent with the possibility that evaluations of Ko account for more of the remaining variance than evaluations of Hou.

Table 2. Estimates of Incumbent Voting Choice Models

	Baseline model(1)	Lai and Hou Difference(2)	Lai and Ko Difference(3)	Full Model(4)
Intercept	0.069* (0.086)	0.141 (0.199)	0.603 (1.115)	0.524 (0.971)
Voted for DPP in 2020	58.196*** (26.613)	16.453*** (7.945)	31.061*** (17.650)	22.835*** (13.469)
International status unchanged	0.152+ (0.170)	0.058* (0.077)	0.015* (0.026)	0.009** (0.016)
International status worse	0.013** (0.019)	0.022* (0.038)	0.035+ (0.068)	0.041+ (0.079)
Cross-Strait relations deteriorated	0.412 (0.439)	0.886 (1.104)	0.302 (0.454)	0.349 (0.531)
Level of Anxiety about Potential Conflict	0.308** (0.111)	0.333** (0.135)	0.189** (0.107)	0.192** (0.108)
Level of Anger over China's Coercion	2.509** (0.838)	2.021+ (0.767)	1.718 (0.828)	1.670 (0.810)
Difference in Feeling between Lai and Hou		1.563*** (0.099)		1.201* (0.095)
Difference in Feeling between Lai and Ko			2.233*** (0.204)	2.098*** (0.198)
Taiwanese identity	4.093*** (1.234)	2.940** (0.979)	2.554* (1.008)	2.494* (0.996)
International status unchanged and Anxiety	1.787 (0.683)	1.927 (0.837)	2.355 (1.335)	2.649+ (1.511)
International status worse and Anxiety	3.523** (1.666)	3.010* (1.573)	1.977 (1.244)	1.809 (1.148)
Cross-Strait relations deteriorated and Anxiety	1.388 (0.494)	1.390 (0.560)	2.524+ (1.302)	2.706 (1.407)
International status unchanged and Anger	0.764	1.091	1.552	1.726

	Baseline model(1)	Lai and Hou Difference(2)	Lai and Ko Difference(3)	Full Model(4)
	(0.292)	(0.485)	(0.867)	(0.998)
International status worse and Anger	0.641	0.764	1.055	1.158
	(0.285)	(0.363)	(0.625)	(0.687)
Cross-Strait relations deteriorated and Anger	0.824	0.726	0.609	0.560
	(0.287)	(0.285)	(0.296)	(0.278)
Num.Obs.	793	784	783	783
AIC	465.3	394.7	282.3	278.6
BIC	563.5	497.3	384.9	385.9
Log.Lik.	-211.666	-175.350	-119.147	-116.302

Note: Values presented are Odds Ratios (e^b) from a logistic regression model. Standard errors are in parentheses below the OR. The reference category for “International Status” is “better”. The reference category for “Cross-Strait relations” is “Improve and the same”. The regression sample (N = 793) reflects listwise deletion of respondents missing on any model variable, driven primarily by non-response on the 2020 and 2024 vote-choice items.

Significance: † $p < 0.10$; $p < 0.05$; $p < 0.01$; $p < 0.001$

Source: Chen (2024)

Of the six cognition $\times$ emotion interaction terms, only the interaction between anxiety and worsening international status receives support, and only in the baseline specification and the model controlling for the Lai–Hou feeling thermometer difference. Although the estimate remains positive in the more conservative specifications, it is no longer statistically distinguishable from zero once both candidate-feeling differences are included. Most notably, the interaction between anxiety and perceptions of Taiwan's worsening international status is significant and positive in the baseline model and Model 2. This reflects a shift from anxiety's baseline effect: under conditions of stable or improving international status—the reference category in the model—an anxious voter's caution expresses itself as risk-averse punishment, as switching away from a government they are worried about is the comparatively 'safe' move (OR

= 0.308, $p < .01$), reflecting vigilance and blame attribution (Forgas 1995; Marcus, Neuman, and MacKuen 2000). Under perceived decline in the nation's global standing, anxiety increases the odds of voting for the ruling party ($OR \approx 3.523$). The antagonistic interaction--simple predictors and the interaction have opposite signs--suggests that anxious voters who perceive Taiwan's international status as worsening consolidate support around familiar, experienced leadership rather than risk switching to an untested opposition during a period they already perceive as dangerous — consistent with the risk-aversion mechanism proposed in H4, in which the relative riskiness of political change, not just the underlying threat, shapes the electoral consequences of anxiety. This pattern is consistent with appraisal theory's prediction that emotions shape coping behavior through context-dependent attributions, though here the relevant attribution concerns the relative risk of change versus continuity rather than a shift in blame.

By contrast, interactions involving anger are not statistically significant. The non-significant interactions involving anger suggest that this emotion exerts a generalized rather than conditional influence on voting behavior. While anxiety's impact depends on citizens' appraisal of Taiwan's international status, anger appears less contingent on perceived national conditions. This aligns with research showing that anger activates approach motivation and defensive solidarity, producing stable, directional effects that are less shaped by contextual appraisals. Overall, the results provide evidence for a context-dependent association involving anxiety but little evidence that anger's electoral association varies systematically across retrospective evaluations.

Table 3. Results of Hypothesis Tests

Hypothesis	Prediction	Verdict
H1(Cognitive Punishment)	Perceived deterioration in international status and cross-Strait relations significantly reduces	Supported

	incumbent support	
H2(Anxiety-induced Weakening)	Higher anxiety significantly reduces incumbent support	Supported
H3(Anger-induced Strengthening)	Higher anger at external coercion induces incumbent support, conditional on incumbent's deterrence-oriented stance	Supported in the baseline specification (Table 2, Model 1) and in a specification controlling for party-level affect alone (Appendix Table C8, Model 2). As anticipated theoretically — given anger's expected operation through voters' standing candidate and party attachments — the association attenuates to non-significance once candidate-level affect is included, whether alone (Table 2, Model 4) or jointly with party-level affect (Appendix Table C8, Model 3). This attenuation is consistent with, rather than a departure from, the mechanism proposed in the theory section.
H4(Anxiety-Contingent Reversal)	Under perceived decline, anxiety attenuates or reverses the negative effect of that evaluation on incumbent support	Supported in the baseline specification and under party-level affect controls (Table 2, Model 1; Appendix Table C8, Model 2), but not robust once candidate-level affect controls are included, alone or jointly with party-level affect (Table 2, Model 4; Appendix Table C8, Model 3)

Non-focal Interaction (Anger and evaluations)	The interactions between anger and evaluations are not significant; anger exerts a generalized rather than conditional influence	Discussed
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Note: Appendix Table C8 reports three additional specifications varying the affect controls: party-level thermometers only, and candidate- and party-level thermometers jointly. See Robustness Check section for discussion.

Source: Author

I use the baseline model to compute the predicted probability of voting for the incumbent party.⁴ Figure 1 shows a predicted probability plot, illustrating anxiety decreases DPP support when international status is perceived as “about the same”, but less so—or even reverses—when international status becomes worse. Across all levels of anxiety, retrospective evaluation of international status has a strong effect on the predicted DPP vote probability. The solid line indicates that individuals who believe Taiwan's international status has remained unchanged have a consistently high predicted probability of voting for the DPP (around 0.75). The dashed line reveals that individuals who believe Taiwan's international status has been worse have a consistently low predicted probability of voting for the DPP (around 0.25 to 0.50). This divergence indicates that the two groups react very differently to increasing anxiety, leading to a significant crossover effect. The effect of anxiety is dependent on the voter's underlying belief about Taiwan's international standing.

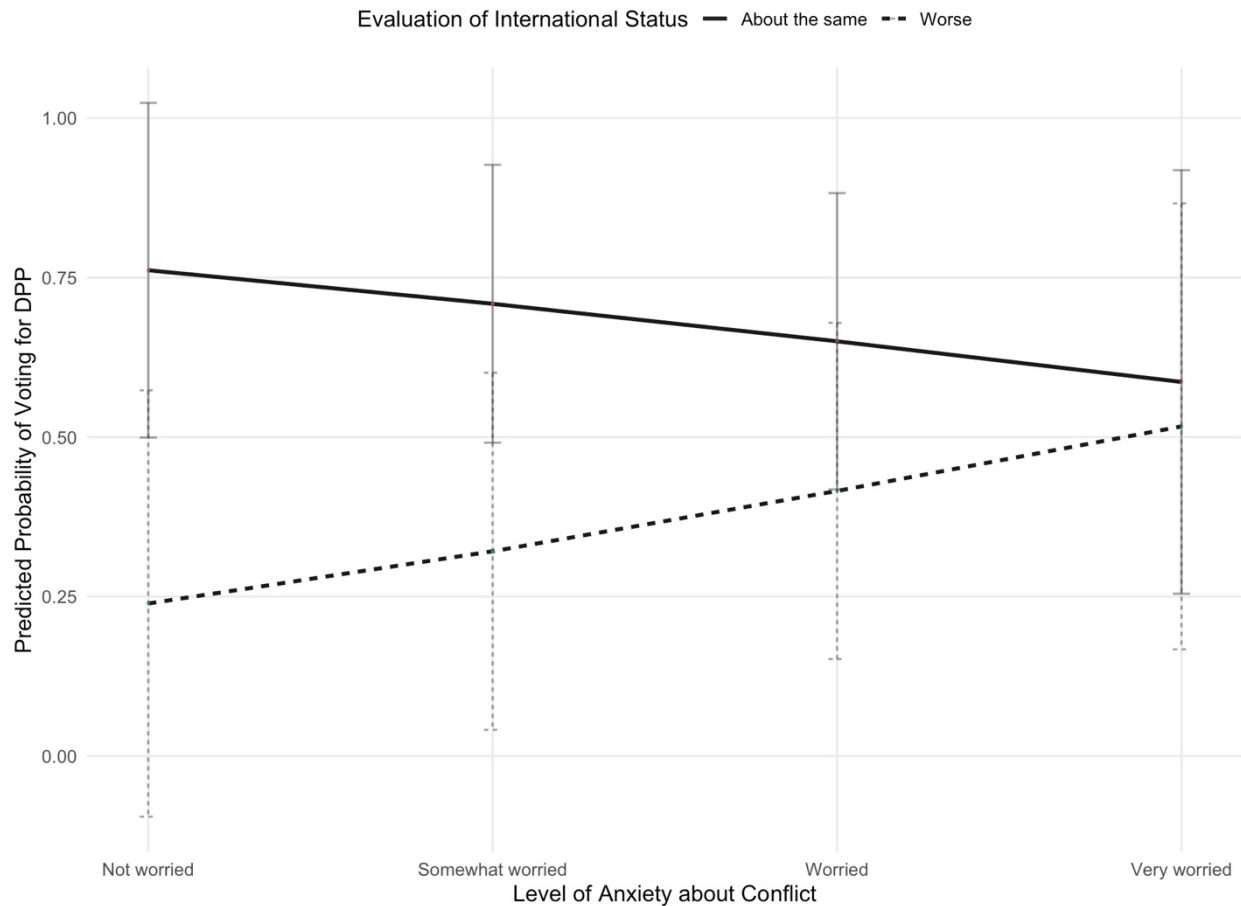


Figure 1. Interaction of Anxiety and Retrospective Evaluation of Taiwan's International Status
Source: Chen (2024)

Figure 2 shows two lines with positive slopes, indicating that as the anger over China's coercion increases (moving from "Not upset at all" to "Very upset"), the predicted probability of voting for the DPP increases. Individuals who believe Taiwan's international status has remained unchanged have a higher predicted probability of voting for the DPP (ranging from approximately 0.50 to 0.78). The effect of anger in driving votes toward the DPP is attenuated among those who feel Taiwan's international standing has worsened, though as reported above, the corresponding interaction term is not statistically significant ($OR \approx 0.641$). This visual pattern should be read as illustrative of the model's point estimates rather than as independent evidence of a genuine conditional effect.

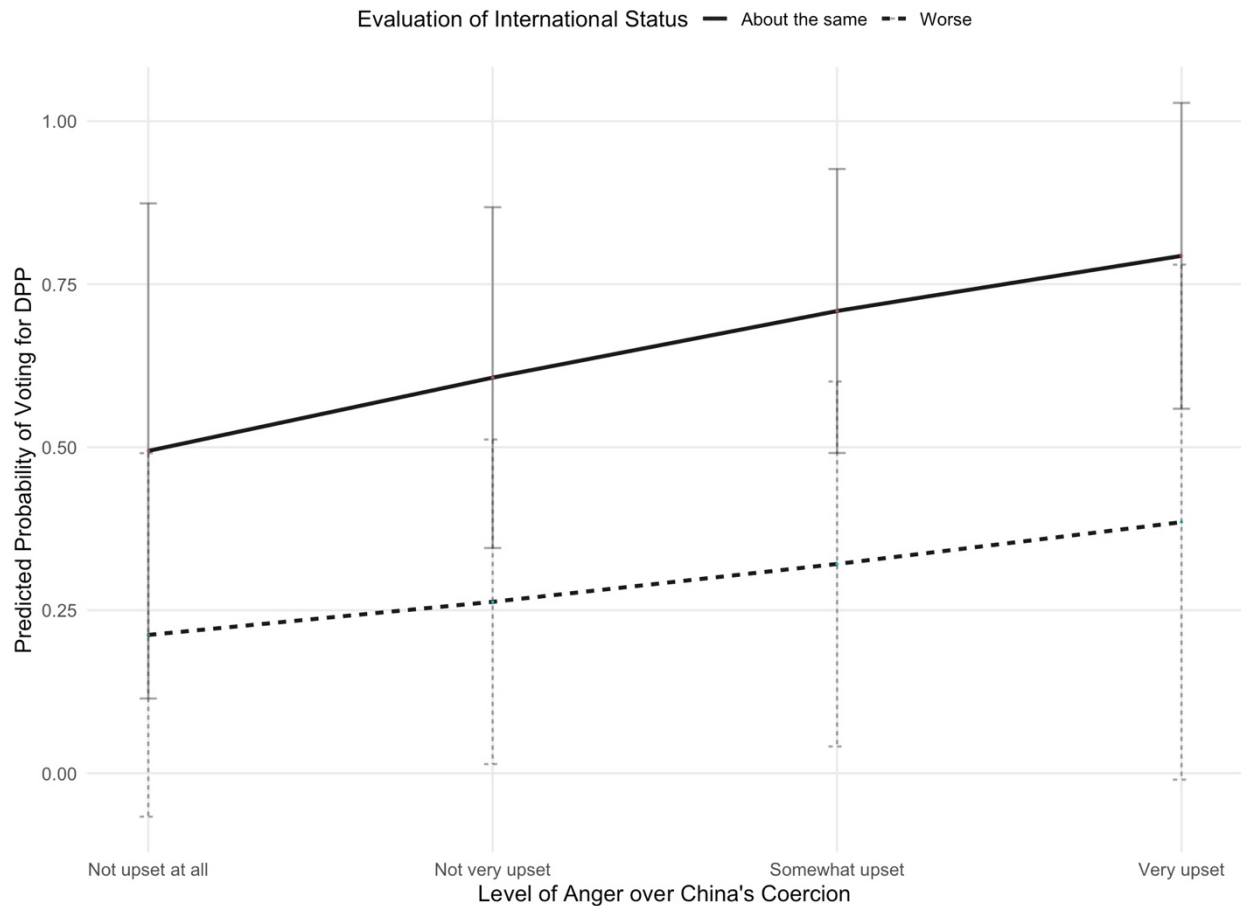


Figure 2. Interaction of Anger and Retrospective Evaluation of Taiwan's International Status
Source: Chen (2024)

The second and third model add difference in feeling-thermometer between Lai and Hou, and between Lai and Ko, respectively. In the second model, retrospective evaluations of Taiwan's international standing continue to be significant predictors of voting choice. Anxiety over potential conflict and anger over encircling of Chinese warplanes and warships also remain significant when the model includes the feeling-thermometer difference between Lai and Hou. Because these two candidates clearly represented opposing positions on cross-Strait relations, anger about China's military coercion was associated with support for the DPP's more assertive defense stance, a reaction not fully captured by the evaluative difference between Lai and Hou.

About the interaction term, people who are anxious about potential conflict and consider that Taiwan's international status is worse are likely to vote for the DPP.

In the third model, assessment of Taiwan's international standing and anxiety over potential conflict are related to voting choice. However, anger becomes less influential once the difference between Lai and Ko is considered, likely because his narrative blurs the emotional boundary of the "out-group". Voters who felt angry about the cross-Strait situation could still find expressive satisfaction in supporting Ko, who offered an alternative outlet for frustration without fully endorsing confrontation. Thus, the inclusion of Lai–Ko differences statistically captures part of the emotional channel through which anger influenced vote choice. Similarly, I visualize the interaction between evaluation of international standing and different levels of anxiety and anger in Appendix D. Compared to the baseline model, the difference in the predicted probability between two categories of evaluation of international standing becomes smaller.

Robustness Check

Endogeneity remains a concern in observational studies because emotions, evaluations, and vote choice may be jointly determined. All models include strong controls for partisan predispositions, such as prior vote choice and Taiwanese identity, reducing the possibility that anxiety and anger simply proxy partisan predispositions. Because emotions refer specifically to potential conflict and Chinese coercion—events not plausibly caused by vote intention—the risk of straightforward reverse causality is reduced. Candidate evaluations may themselves be downstream consequences of these emotional reactions, specifications including feeling-thermometer differences likely provide lower-bound estimates of the emotional associations. This does not fully resolve the broader sequencing problem inherent to post-election measurement, however, since emotions and evaluations captured after the election may still partly reflect ex post rationalization of vote choice rather than antecedents of it.

Moreover, the core results remain stable across alternative specifications shown in Appendix. Restricting the sample to respondents who voted for the DPP in 2020 (Table C2) displays that anxiety continues to reduce, and anger to increase, the odds of again supporting the incumbent, indicating the effect is not solely an artifact of partisan sorting. To more directly assess whether anger's incumbent-benefiting effect reflects a genuine rally dynamic, I also restrict the sample to respondents who did not vote DPP in 2020 (Table C3). As in Table 2, the dependent variable remains the binary incumbent-support indicator (DPP vs. either opposition candidate); the two columns instead vary which comparative feeling-thermometer difference is included as a control. In the specification controlling for the Lai–Hou difference, anger is associated with increased odds of incumbent support ($OR = 3.68, p < .10$); the corresponding coefficient in the specification controlling for the Lai–Ko difference is similarly signed but not significant ($OR = 2.99, ns$). Given the reduced power in this subsample, this evidence is suggestive rather than definitive, but it is consistent with anger's effect extending at least partially beyond the DPP's existing 2020 coalition.

A multinomial logit model distinguishing KMT and TPP as separate alternatives to the DPP (Table C4) is consistent with the main results: anxiety significantly increases the odds of choosing either opposition candidate over Lai (KMT vs. DPP: $OR = 2.98, p < .05$; TPP vs. DPP: $OR = 3.46, p < .01$), while anger significantly reduces those odds (KMT vs. DPP: $OR = 0.40, p < .10$; TPP vs. DPP: $OR = 0.41, p < .05$). The anxiety-by-international-status interaction central to H4 also replicates in this specification (KMT vs. DPP: $OR = 0.36, p < .10$; TPP vs. DPP: $OR = 0.23, p < .01$). Adding candidate feeling-thermometer differences to the multinomial models (Tables C5–C6) leaves this pattern intact, and re-estimating the baseline model with survey weights (Table C7) yields substantively identical coefficients throughout.

To more systematically assess whether anxiety and anger operate independently of partisan and candidate affect, as opposed to treating candidate feeling-thermometer differences primarily as a robustness check, I estimated three additional specifications varying the affect

controls (Appendix Table C8): candidate-level thermometers only (reproducing Table 2, Model 4), party-level thermometers only (DPP–KMT and DPP–TPP differences), and both sets of thermometers included jointly. Anxiety's main effect is stable across all three (OR range: 0.180–0.192, $p < .01$ or better). Anger and the anxiety $\times$ worsening-international-status interaction central to H4 reach significance only under party-level controls alone (anger: OR = 2.155, $p < .10$; interaction: OR = 3.537, $p < .05$); both lose significance once candidate-level thermometers are included, whether alone or jointly with party-level thermometers. Because the Lai–Ko candidate-affect difference remains a strong, independent predictor in every specification in which it appears (OR $\approx$ 2.0–2.1, $p < .001$), while the party-level DPP–TPP measure loses significance once candidate affect is added, the party-only specification should be viewed as comparatively under-controlled rather than as evidence of a robust effect that candidate-level controls obscure. Consequently, the candidate-inclusive specification (Table 2, Model 4) is my primary and most conservative test, and this comparison is evidence of reinforcing, rather than complicating, the asymmetry reported above: anxiety's effect is robust to every affect specification tested, while anger's and H4's are not.

Collectively, these tests demonstrate that cognition and emotion operate as distinct, mutually informative dimensions of vote choice, broadly supporting the dual-pathway framework. While anxiety's effect proves exceptionally robust across all specifications—including models controlling for current partisanship, Taiwanese identity, multinomial outcomes, and survey weights—the estimates for anger and the anxiety-decline interaction (H4) attenuate once comparative candidate affect is introduced.

Conclusion

These findings provide evidence that ‘rational’ cognitive evaluations and ‘emotional’ reactions are not substitutes but complementary outputs of appraisal. Voters who feel anxious about potential conflict in the Taiwan Strait are more likely to support opposition parties, while anger is

more sensitive to controls for candidate evaluations, suggesting that reactions to Chinese coercion are intertwined with comparative impressions of political leaders. In the primary specification, anger directed at China's military coercion is associated with increased support for the incumbent DPP. However, this association is no longer statistically distinguishable from zero once both comparative candidate-feeling measures are controlled simultaneously, indicating that anger's incumbent-benefiting effect partly overlaps with candidate-centered affect. Since my subsample analysis (Table C3) finds only suggestive evidence of non-DPP or independent voters' rallying behind the incumbent due to anger, this pattern is consistent with defensive solidarity against an external adversary — a more conservative description than a full rally effect (Mueller 1970; Lambert, Schott, and Scherer 2011; Falcó-Gimeno, Muñoz, and Pannico 2025).

Moreover, in the multinomial specification without candidate-affect controls, anger's incumbent-benefiting effect is not confined to the KMT contrast, where Hou's dialogue-oriented platform stood in starkest opposition to the DPP's deterrence stance, but extends to the TPP contrast as well (Table C4). This result is consistent with anger operating as a comparatively generalized mobilizer of incumbent loyalty rather than an effect narrowly contingent on the specific deterrence/dialogue framing, in line with Webster's (2018, 2020) account of anger as a stable driver of political engagement and resolute partisanship across contexts. This pattern would suggest that the boundary condition proposed in H3 is better understood as amplifying rather than uniquely activating anger's incumbent-benefiting effect.

The primary implication of this study is that anxiety and anger operate through distinct, and at times opposing, mechanisms — and that anxiety's own effect is itself contingent on context. Under stable or improving conditions, anxiety appears to heighten sensitivity to the incumbent's policy failures; but under conditions of severe perceived national decline, this same anxiety appears to reverse direction, leading voters to consolidate around familiar leadership rather than punish it further. For a country under external pressure, this pattern suggests that a government's ability to mobilize a resistant public may depend in part on whether citizens'

anxiety is channeled into actionable anger and defiance, rather than left to heighten risk-averse caution. Should anxiety predominate over anger, a preference for non-confrontational continuity may take precedence, though this remains a speculative extension.

The second implication is related to the role of affect in politics. This research provides evidence for the function of two core psychological mechanisms—*anxiety and anger*—in shaping political behavior under security threat. Importantly, these mechanisms are not confined to wartime or international crises. “Peacetime” issues can also be understood as alternative forms of threat that activate the same emotional systems of appraisal and response. For example, rising anger during domestic political conflict can heighten motivation for aggressive or punitive action (Schnakenberg and Wayne 2024), while feelings of humiliation—appraising oneself as unjustly demeaned—may fuel risk-taking behavior aimed at restoring honor or autonomy (Barnhart 2020). Research on racial politics demonstrates that heightened anger among white individuals correlates with increased support for conservative policies (Banks 2014). These examples are broadly consistent with a coherent emotional logic across contexts, whether the perceived threat stems from foreign coercion, economic instability, or political confrontation.

The third implication concerns polarization. Previous polarization literature has emphasized anger arising from identity conflict between in-group and out-group members (e.g., Achen and Bartels 2016; Hetherington and Weiler 2018; Iyengar and Westwood 2015). More recently, scholars have identified mechanisms through which external threats can *reduce* polarization, as shared threats generate common assessments of an adversary and encourage in-group consolidation (Myrick 2021; Kaiser and Pedersen 2026). My findings suggest a more nuanced relationship between emotion, threat, and polarization than either strand of this literature implies on its own. Before accounting for differences in candidate feeling-thermometer evaluations, anger toward China's coercion is positively associated with incumbent support, consistent with a confrontational response that consolidates support behind the incumbent as the candidate best positioned to stand firm against the external adversary. Anxiety, by contrast, is

negatively associated with incumbent support, and this relationship persists even after controlling for candidate-level affect. Rather than reflecting a stable disposition like anger, this pattern is consistent with a risk-averse response that is itself contingent on how citizens appraise the trajectory of the external threat. Anxious voters may calibrate their response to whether conditions are perceived as stable or deteriorating; the same emotion can either consolidate support around the incumbent as the safer choice or erode it, depending on citizens' real-time threat assessments, whereas anger's effect remains comparatively anchored to pre-existing candidate and partisan attachments. Thus, whether external threats can reduce affective divisions may hinge on which emotion is elicited and how the threats are perceived.

As noted above, anxiety and anger in this design are elicited by related but distinct objects—anxiety by the prospect of conflict, anger by the specific act of Chinese coercion—so some of the divergent effects reported here may partly reflect this difference in object rather than emotion type alone. This concern may be more consequential for anger than for anxiety, since anxiety has been shown to generalize across distinct targets to a greater extent than anger, which tends to remain more target-specific (Huddy, Feldman, and Cassese 2007). It is necessary to consider experimental designs that make causal inference about the sequencing between cognition and emotion possible, and that hold the object of emotional appraisal constant—for instance, presenting all respondents with an identical description of Chinese coercion while independently manipulating appraisal dimensions such as certainty and attributability—to more cleanly separate the effects of emotion type from the effects of what is being evaluated.

Moreover, while Taiwan provides a compelling case, its unique geopolitical environment may limit external validity. The dual-pathway framework advanced here may be tested in other democracies confronting security pressure, such as South Korea or Japan, where citizens likewise face contested attributions of blame for external threats.⁵

Finally, the anxiety and anger measures used here may partially proxy partisan affect rather than purely environment-elicited emotion. Furthermore, while the anxiety item specifically

asks about military conflict between Taiwan and mainland China to isolate cross-Strait security concerns, it may still reflect broader domestic political noise. The heightened uncertainty of the 2024 election—including the collapsed blue-white coalition and subsequent three-way race—could have elevated general anxiety, subtly influencing responses to this specific question. The lagged 2020 vote-choice control included in the models addresses stable partisan predispositions but cannot account for a campaign-specific shock of this kind, since it necessarily predates it. The cross-sectional design does not allow researchers to separate external from domestic sources of anxiety, and this interpretation should be treated with corresponding caution. Future research could leverage panel surveys that measure baseline partisan affect and emotional dispositions before major international events, then reinterview respondents following episodes of military coercion or diplomatic crises (Ladd and Lenz 2008). Such designs would allow us to isolate within-person changes in anxiety and anger attributable to external events rather than stable partisan attachments.

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Notes

1. For details about Taiwan’s 2024 presidential election, see Appendix A.
2. Among the 642 respondents identified as non-DPP voters (including “don’t know” or refusal) in 2020, only 442 complete cases were retained in the full regression models due to listwise deletion. Item non-response accounts for the remaining cases.
3. I control for gender, age (20 to 29 years old, 30 to 39 years old, 40 to 49 years old, 50 to 59 years old, and more than 60 years old), and education (elementary school, high school, and university) in every regression model. For convenience of interpretation, those coefficients are not shown in the tables.
4. Predicted probabilities were calculated using the fitted values from the logistic regression model. For each combination of anxiety level (1-4) and perception of international status (“About the same” and “Worse”), I set all other covariates to their observed means (for continuous variables) or modal categories (for categorical variables). I then used the

estimated coefficients to compute the linear predictor (log-odds), which was transformed into a probability using the logistic function. 95% confidence intervals were derived using simulation from the variance–covariance matrix of the model.

The `datagrid()` and `predictions()` functions in the `marginaleffects` package in R were used to generate predicted values and their 95% confidence intervals.

5. China's recent aggravation gets on Korean and Japanese people's nerve. In Korea, an increasing number of anti-China rallies not only mark escalation of anti-Chinese tourism but also reflect tensions with China (Lee 2025; Rashid 2025). In a 2024 opinion poll, 90 percent of Japanese respondents had a negative view of China, citing the Senkaku Island and Taiwan issues (Japan Times 2024). As for Russia, Japan and Korea have joined Western sanctions after the invasion of Ukraine. The growing embrace of Russia and North-Korea also increases the tensions between Russia and these two countries.

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